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Steele claims mistreatment after ruling



Cook County Board of Review Commissioner Samantha Steele exits the Daley Center following a not guilty verdict in her DUI trial on Tuesday. **ANTONIO PEREZ/TRIBUNE**

Cook Board of Review commissioner found not guilty of DUI by judge in 2-day trial

By **A.D. Quig**
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Fresh off her acquittal on charges of drunken driving, Board of Review Commissioner Samantha Steele is crying foul over treatment by the media, critics and the state's attorney's office since she crashed a car on Chicago's North Side in November 2024.

Following a two-day bench trial,

Cook County Judge Donald Suriano on Tuesday found Steele not guilty, saying prosecutors had not met the burden to prove beyond a reasonable doubt that she was under the influence of alcohol. Steele and her attorney said the extent of the prosecution — a two-day trial with multiple witnesses — was uncommon.

"If I were anyone else, they wouldn't have tried this because

there was no evidence," Steele told the Tribune.

Prosecutors alleged Steele was drunk when she crashed into two cars along Ashland Avenue and clearly showed impaired judgment. They called witnesses who testified they smelled alcohol, that Steele's eyes were glassy or bloodshot or that she slurred her speech.

Police also found a bottle of wine in the passenger wheel well. Steele had resisted some orders from police at the scene until Scott Britton, a friend and attorney, advised her to over the phone, video showed. But the judge said that was

not sufficient evidence and ruled she was not guilty.

Steele acknowledged she'd had alcohol earlier that day at a brunch, which was why the sealed bottle of wine was in her car. But the crash was several hours later and she said it happened because a tumor on her pituitary gland hit her optical nerve, affecting her peripheral vision. The tumor was removed last April, Steele said.

That medical emergency did not come up during the trial. Steele's attorney, John Fotopoulos, said

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Two eaglets are seen in their nest, right, in Chicago's South Deering neighborhood while an eagle stands watch on Thursday.

CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

'THE YEAR BALD EAGLES DECIDED TO MAKE HISTORY'

Three eaglets born in Chicago for first time in a century

By **Christiana Freitag**
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Hyde Park birding couple Pat and Steve Pearson have ventured out to Chicago's Southeast Side once a week for over a year keeping their eyes and camera focused on two bald eagles soaring above South Deering.

The couple watched the birds carry large twigs high into the treetops near Park No. 597, just south of Indian Ridge Marsh, gradually building a massive nest.

They weren't sure the nest would produce a baby eagle — but they hoped.

The national bird hasn't been born in Chicago in over a century.

That changed on April 28, when the Pearsons spotted a small grayish-brown eaglet peek its head above the nest.

Pat Pearson, 68, said she was overcome with emotion when she saw the baby.

"Just out of the blue, there was this rather scruffy-looking little bird sticking its head out there," she said. "When I saw that baby's head pop up for the first time and my husband standing right there, I literally teared up."

Steve Pearson, 80, snapped a photo of the history-making

raptor.

The couple initially kept the discovery quiet, worried potential crowds would disturb the nesting birds.

"It's not about us, it's about them," she added.

The Chicago Park District called the successful nesting an important ecological achievement for the city in a Wednesday announcement. By Thursday, observers and park officials confirmed there were actually two eaglets in the nest.

"It's an inevitable milestone that we've been waiting to happen," said Edward Warden,

president of the Chicago Ornithological Society. "It was only a matter of time because of the amount of work that's been done on Chicago's waterways, on Chicago's ecology. We knew that they were going to return some day."

Over the weekend, Warden said birders observed another eagle nest with at least one eaglet at Oak Woods Cemetery in the nearby Grand Crossing neighborhood.

"This is the year bald eagles decided to make history, twice," he said.

Warden said Chicago — particularly the Calumet region — provides ideal habitat for bald eagles because of its extensive

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US debt reaches alarming milestone

Muted reaction in DC after deficit tops GDP

By **Tony Romm**
THE NEW YORK TIMES

WASHINGTON — The U.S. government learned last week that it may have reached an unfortunate milestone: The size of its debt surpassed the nation's total economic output.

It was a striking imbalance, according to early estimates, one that the country has experienced only in rare circumstances — briefly during the pandemic and in the aftermath of World War II. But the development barely seemed to register in the nation's capital, where few policymakers bothered to acknowledge the latest warning sign about the government's poor fiscal health.

The root of the problem is well-documented.

U.S. debt has soared in recent years because of a mismatch between federal spending and tax revenue, one complicated by a rapidly aging population, which has driven up costs across government.

For economists, the fear is that these conditions are inching the United States toward a fiscal crisis, one in which its debt is so great that the country can't easily afford to pay the rising interest on it. But their warnings have long gone unheeded in Washington, calcifying the strains on the government's balance sheet in ways that President Donald Trump's agenda is expected to exacerbate.

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INSIDE

Officer remembered as 'best of all of us'

The city prepared to say its final goodbye to Chicago police Officer John Bartholomew, as visitation for the slain 10-year CPD veteran was held in Edgewater on Thursday. **Chicagoland, Page A3**

US says attacks on warships intercepted

The U.S. military said it intercepted Iranian attacks on three Navy ships in the Strait of Hormuz and "targeted Iranian military facilities responsible for attacking U.S. forces." **Nation & World, Page B4**

Second City show hilarious, oh so true

"Pandemonium, Please Hold" is a neat encapsulation of how we poor suckers attempting to calm the chaos of our lives usually find only an irritating bot on the other end of the line. **Arts & Entertainment**

Chicago Sinfonietta will pause concerts and lay off staff

Organization enters 'renewal period' to steady its finances

By **Hannah Edgar**
FOR THE CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The Chicago Sinfonietta — one of the metro area's leading orchestras and among just a few in the world devoted to advancing racial equity — announced Thursday that it would pause the vast majority of its artistic and educational activities during the 2026-27 season.

The organization is instead entering a "strategic renewal period" to regain its financial footing prior to its 40th anniversary season, according to a statement.

During that time, the organization will lay off its seven-person administrative staff at the end of the month, leaving president and CEO Sidney Jackson as the sole full-time employee. (This weekend's concerts of George Gershwin's "Rhapsody in Blue," a Miles Davis tribute by Seth Pae and William Dawson's "Negro Folk Symphony," slated for Friday and Sunday in Naperville and Evanston, will still be performed.)

"We're in the process of figuring out how we will show up outside of a subscription season," Jackson told the Tribune.

The move is one of the most drastic yet undertaken by an area organization to counteract the

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The Chicago Sinfonietta, led by music director Mei-Ann Chen, at Symphony Center in 2015. **TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/TRIBUNE**

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